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Master's Thesis – Project Report

Visible Care

What could an inclusive, caring institution be for student-parents?
A critical design inquiry into institutional practices of inclusion and care.



Author: Kashish Shabee
Supervisor: Yanki Lee
Examiner: Mathilda Tham
University: Linnaeus University
Term: 25VT
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A critical design inquiry into institutional practices of inclusion and care.

KASHISH SHABEE
MASTER'S DESIGN + CHANGE
Linnaeus University Växjö, Sweden

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Abstract

With the prospect of bringing socially sustainable and positive change, this design project examines the struggles and challenges pregnant and parenting students face in academic settings. The lack of official institutional support causes fear of judgment, isolation and stress among these students. These challenges often cause academic withdrawal and increase the dropout rate in higher education. Pregnant and parenting students are usually marginalised, and their needs are overlooked in an educational environment. This design project investigates the difficulties for parenting students and critically addresses the challenges and gaps in the supportive policies at Linnaeus University, Växjö, Sweden. The process integrates visual autoethnography and non-intrusive participatory methods to highlight systemic policy gaps and advocate change by employing the social design principles and a practice-based research approach. By documenting personal experiences through visual autoethnography and developing accessible forms of participation, the project seeks to raise awareness, recognise key barriers and foster dialogue to push for policy reform that supports the academic success of parenting students. The outcomes include the speculative support guide brochure, designed as a tool for advocacy. At the same time, participatory platforms provide a space for collective reflections and visibility, offering a supportive forum for the well-being of pregnant and parenting students. Aligned with Metadesign principles, this project moves away from fixed solutions and instead creates an open-ended supportive forum. This project aims to foster a culture where pregnant and parenting students will be empowered and entitled to support in achieving their academic goals.

KEYWORDS: Pregnancy, sustainable, social design, research methods

2. INTRODUCTION

Throughout history, education has been offered to those who can pursue it; education was a privilege reserved for men. For many years, men dominated educational institutions, filled lecture halls with advanced knowledge, while women were expected to be at home and have caregiving responsibilities. Their education was restricted by societal norms and cultural customs; for decades, women were obligated to stay at home. Women's primary roles were within the domestic sphere, and education was not considered necessary for them. (Kalodimou & Kapalika, 2023). However, times have changed. Women have fought for their rights to learn, study, and contribute to the world beyond domestic life. In this era, men and women sit side by side in education, learning together and striving for a future where education is a shared endeavour.

However, while gender barriers in academics no longer exist, another limitation remains unaddressed- PREGNANCY. The education system has evolved, yet female students face significant challenges: "Having a child can shift a student's career trajectory, often moving them away from academia and prestigious tenure-track positions at research-intensive universities" (Mirick & Wladkowski, 2018, p.171). Pregnancy, like education, is about time; it is a transition, a temporary state, yet profoundly significant. It is a phase of growth, just like learning; yet, when a woman becomes pregnant during her studies, the system often responds with rigidity, imposing mandatory leave, academic pauses, and the expectation that she must step aside. A pregnant student is encouraged to take leave or suspend her studies as if learning and motherhood cannot co-exist. Nevertheless, why do we treat pregnancy as a vulnerable state rather than a natural and essential part of life?

From a global perspective, the world needs more babies due to the ageing population and lower fertility rate. Fertility is a concern for the world's economists. According to studies, the falling birth rate will permanently modify the demographic makeup of the largest global economies in the next few years. Former Google CEO Eric Schmidt states, "In aggregate, all the demographics say there's going to be a shortage of humans for jobs. Literally too many jobs and not enough people for at least the next 30 years." He also addresses that if people continue having fewer children, then this will lead to a demographic crisis, companies and governments must prepare for the "low-fertility future". (Goodkind, 2024)

In modern society, women actively contribute to household finances and pursue higher education, which opens pathways to better career opportunities for them. However, pregnancy is a temporary condition- whether planned or unplanned- that can occur during their studies. The fear of judgment and lack of support discourage women from having children while studying, leading some to delay childbearing.

While age is a factor in female fertility, it is essential to understand that delaying childbirth for education and career is not the reason that directly causes infertility. According to the Eunice Kennedy Shiver National Institute of Child Health and Human Development (n.d.), female fertility gradually declines after the mid-30s. This highlights the difficult choices young women face when prioritising education and career, often leading them to postpone

pregnancy to avoid academic disruption. However, postponement can increase the risk of age-related infertility later in life.

We need students to learn, and we need children for the future. These two certainties are not contradictory. If educational institutions exist to prepare individuals for the world, then why do they struggle to accommodate one of the most fundamental aspects of human existence? This is not about fairness; it is about balance. If education is to shape the future, it must support both life and knowledge.

When I searched for information about the accommodations for pregnant students during my pregnancy at my University, I found nothing related to pregnant students, no guidelines, no support, no official policies. My studies were totally at my teacher's discretion, as there were no institutional policies in place to address my situation. According to Donna Haraway (1988), knowledge is always situated; it derives from the specific, embodied experience instead of an objective perspective. Educational institutes often have this assumption of a "Neutral" or "Universal" student, one with no caregiving responsibilities. However, this perspective is not neutral; it is formed by the framework that excludes students like me. This design project explores how design can challenge the dominant ways of seeing and create visibility for pregnant and parenting students in educational settings.

"Academic activities are intertwined with challenging competitions. Therefore, motherhood responsibilities impose a large burden on students' shoulders. The academic community focuses mainly on success, development, and never-ending competitions without providing any support. Therefore, taking on motherhood along with studies is not considered normal in universities." – **Behboodi Moghadam, Ordibeheshti, Esmaeili, & Salsali, 2017**

3. CONTEXT

3.1. World Economy and Low Fertility Future

In a world where, a few decades ago, people were encouraged to have fewer children, this has now become a cause of worry for countries. In many parts of the world, due to the ageing population and labour shortage, countries promote the concept of *pronatalism*. This refers to the political ideology of making policies to encourage people to have children who later support the state's economy. Like many countries, Sweden also faced demographic challenges

like an ageing population and a lower birth rate. Sweden has implemented family-friendly policies to promote pronatalism.

On the other hand, young individuals in the pursuit of a career and professional growth postpone childbearing at an early age. In the modern world, especially women who earn more money and have high-profile careers, often delay family planning. Not only in professional settings but even to acquire higher education, young women tend to delay childbearing. It is important to understand that age plays a significant role in female fertility. At a young age, women had to make tough decisions like delaying childbearing for their higher education and career goals, which can lead to age-related infertility later in their lives. Postponing pregnancy due to education is not the reason directly concerned with infertility, but if seen, it might be the reason for the falling birth rate crisis in today's modern countries.

It is not necessary that every woman should have a child; it is a completely individual choice. Women have the right to choose whether they want children or not. Another question is, why do women not want children? Might some want them but feel compelled to decide against it? Specifically, in academic settings, it has become a norm that education and motherhood do not coexist because when a woman becomes pregnant during her studies, she is considered less capable. This lack of support and discrimination in education often leads women to delay having children even if they wish to do so.

3.2. The Challenges Faced by Pregnant and Parenting Students in Education

Globally, in higher education, enrollment of women is increasing as compared to men; 29% of them become pregnant during their studies, and 59% of married women with children leave education and take on household and caregiving responsibilities, which changes the future of women and has a negative impact on their education. (Nazir, Abdulghani, & Alduais, 2021). This highlights that pregnant and parenting students, especially women, face significant challenges in academic environments, especially in higher education, such as discrimination, judgment, and a lack of emotional and physical support.

Usually, there is a misconception that pregnant students are less capable of achieving academic goals. Typically, pregnancy is not considered a disease; pregnant students are treated as if they have some disability and need a break from their everyday routine tasks, and studies are something they cannot manage while being pregnant. Navigating studies becomes more difficult for pregnant students when they do not get institutional support. The lack of support causes academic withdrawals and higher dropout rates. Consequently, pregnant students often encounter multiple challenges. The challenges include stress and anxiety, failure in courses being studied, inability to meet family needs, inadequate funding and lack of support from partners. As a result of the challenges, they are sometimes unable to achieve their educational aims (Mamhute, 2011; IJRISS, 2022). In 2018, a quantitative study conducted in Norway highlighted the experience of thirteen pregnant women aged 18- 36 who were undecided about how to resolve their pregnancy. The study highlights the impact of stigma, which influences the participant's interactions and decision-making process. Numerous participants expressed fearing judgment from others, making them highly selective about unveiling their pregnancy. Participants describe this process as a "lonely journey",

indicated by feelings of isolation. The author describes this experience as “an existential loneliness”. Moreover, the study addresses that stigma significantly affects the social support individuals receive during an unintended pregnancy. (Moseson et al., 2019).[1]

Even parenting students face similar challenges; they juggle their student and family lives to achieve academic success. Pregnant and parenting students require support with flexible accommodations and inclusive policies to ensure their academic success.



Figure 2. Illustration, Copyrights K.Shabee (2025)

3.3. Institutional Policies for Pregnant and Parenting Students: A Global and Swedish Perspective

In many countries, there are official institutional policies to support pregnant and parenting students. Universities in countries like the United States and the United Kingdom have implemented policies to support pregnant and caregiving students. Title IX of the United States Education Amendment of 1972 is a Federal civil rights law that prohibits discrimination on the basis of sex—including pregnancy and parental status—in educational programs and activities (Northwood Technical College, n.d.). They obligate educational institutions to provide support and flexible accommodations for pregnant and parenting students to ensure their academic success. However, in Sweden, the situation is entirely different.

[1] This section is adapted from my previous design research, “Challenging stigma and designing creative solutions for pregnant students at Universities in Sweden”, conducted as part of my Master's program at Linnaeus University in 2025.

The Swedish educational system lacks a legal structure to accommodate or support students. Although pregnant students are entitled to parental leave and healthcare benefits under the country's welfare system, there are no formal policies to obligate educational institutions to ensure and accommodate their continued participation in academics. For instance, if pregnant students wish to continue their studies during pregnancy and after childbirth, they have to navigate their studies on their own without official support. Educational institutions are not mandated to provide tailored support, such as alternative instructional programs and tutoring, besides general parental leave. In Sweden, universities just provide information regarding parental leave and health care benefits, which are linked with the state's welfare system, rather than guaranteeing uninterrupted access to studies. (Linnaeus University, n.d.)

3.4. Personal Experience: A Journey Through Pregnancy in Education

This design project is inspired by my experience and the challenges I faced during my unexpected pregnancy in my master's program. Without official accommodations, I reached out to my teachers and requested support and flexibility. The understanding and support of my teachers helped me continue my studies. Throughout this period, I felt guilt and embarrassment that I was asking for extra favours, which led me to stress myself and put in more effort as I did not want to give my peers the impression that I was doing less work. During the whole journey of my pregnancy, along with my studies, I realised that there is an urgent need for official supportive policies for future pregnant students. John Berger (1972) highlights that what we see is formed by the power structure determining who should be visible or who should be overlooked. In higher education, a "default student" is envisioned as young, independent and free from caregiving responsibilities. Those like me, pregnant and parenting students who do not fit that image, are often structurally invisible, not because they do not exist, but because educational institutions' policies do not acknowledge them.

My exploration of this topic from different aspects in previous courses has increased my motivation and directed my focus towards fostering a cultural shift and proposing creative solutions for the social sustainability of pregnant and parenting students. With its diverse student population and commitment to sustainability, Linnaeus University is a focal point for my design project. By integrating social design principles and participatory methods, this design project seeks inclusive, equitable policies and systemic change to foster a culture and supportive forum for the suitability of current and future students regardless of their condition.

3.5. Positioning within Critical and Feminist design

This design project corresponds with design activism and participatory design, where the design intervention acts as a catalyst for dialogue and change. Similarly, there is a study that explores the approach of feminist design as a tool for systemic critique. It highlights how feminist perspectives guide designers' attention toward marginalised groups and help them make decisions during the process of inspiration and ideation. (Buchmüller, 2012). My work resonates with critical design practices that challenge dominant narratives and suggest alternative futures. Dunne and Raby (2013) argue that critical design questions the mainstream ways of thinking and creates designs that provoke reflection. However, my

approach is different from traditional speculative design. Instead of imagining an alternative future, this project is focused on immediate action. My project is not merely a concept; it is happening now. I am not envisioning a future where parenting students is visible, but I am putting in the effort to make it happen through real-world interventions. It is grounded in intersectional feminist epistemologies. I position my lived experiences not as anecdotal but as situated and embodied knowledge. It emphasises the importance of designing with, not for, those who faced multiple forms of marginalisation.

4. DESIGN METHODOLOGY

This design project seeks different approaches in the process. I wanted to develop an open-ended project rather than offer fixed solutions. My project aligns with Metadesign principles, and it's essential to map it out using the Metadesign nest framework. Placing my project in these layers helped me to understand where my project stands on different levels. It also allows me to focus on the systemic issues I aim to critique and what cultural paradigm I want to change. It also guided me to the materiality of my project, allowing me to address the

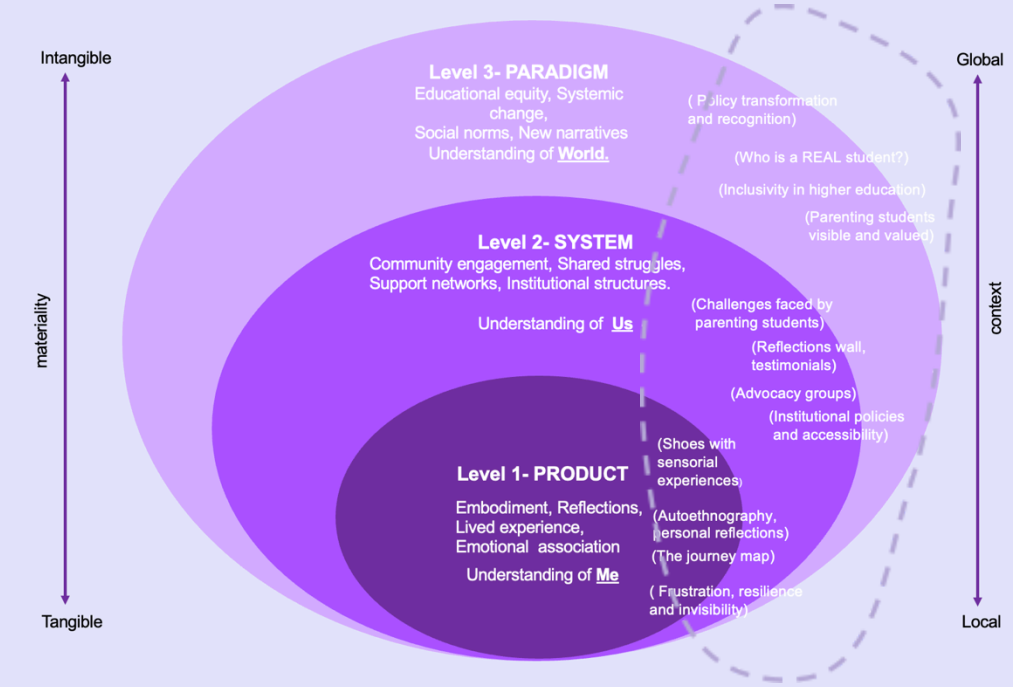


Figure 3. MetaDesign Nest: Visibility and inclusivity for Parenting students in Academia, K.Shabee (2025). Based on Tham, 2013; Lundebye, 2004; Cooper and Young, 2002, (MetaDesign Framework Design Department Linnaeus University)

invisibility of parenting students on campus and gather reflections from both parenting and non-parenting students invisibility of parenting students on campus and gather reflections from both parenting and non-parenting students. To deepen this approach, I draw on German philosopher Martin Heidegger's concept of solicitude (Fürsorge) from Being and Time (1927/1996). It distinguishes between "leaping in" to take over and "leaping ahead" to empower others by creating enabling conditions. Heidegger's perspective of Being in the world complements the Metadesign framework by emphasising the relational, systemic and embedded nature of human existence.

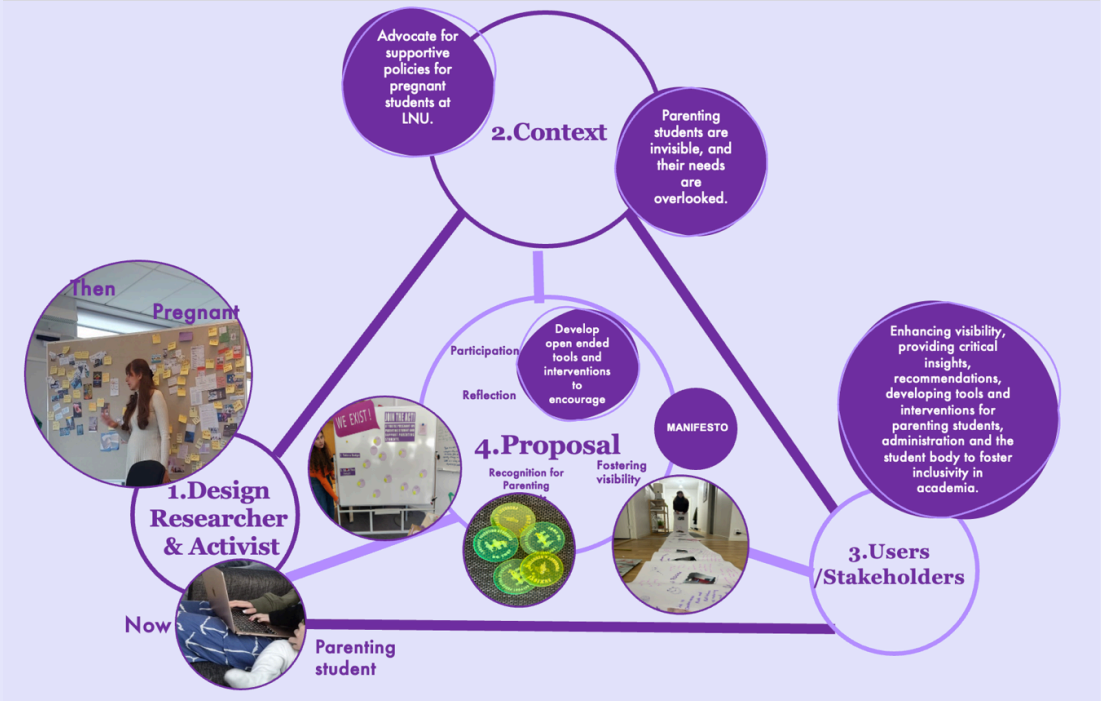


Figure 4. Tetrahedron relational model of writing by John Woods (Woods 2005), K.shabee (2025)

Design is always relational – it emerges from interactions between designers, context, users and proposals. As a researcher and former pregnant and parenting student, I bring both personal experience and critical inquiry. My role is to advocate for inclusivity and challenge institutional norms.

4.1.Practice-based Research

Initially, my research was focused on community-based participatory research methods to investigate barriers faced by pregnant and parenting students at Linnaeus University Växjö, Sweden. To collect data about students' experiences, I designed surveys and approached collaborators such as the student union and the student welfare centre at the university. However, I received no response to my survey, and non-substantial answers from the collaborators created doubt and uncertainty and made me rethink and reassess my approach. This lack of engagement revealed more profound issues, such as invisibility and hesitation to participate.

This challenge led me to shift my approach towards practice-based research methodology, where my own lived experiences as a pregnant and parenting student became the foundation of my exploration. Gabriella Nelson (n.d.), curator of the Designing Motherhood, states, “An equitable society makes it possible for every person to have what they know they need. We are the experts of our own experiences”. Due to a lack of acknowledgement, I positioned my own journey as an essential part of the research.

The practice-based research serves as a mirror of my personal journey, allowing me to contemplate not only the challenges I faced but also the transformative process of design and

change. This approach enables me to involve and engage with my own lived experiences, providing insights into the difficulties of being a pregnant and parenting student. Reflecting on my own journey and documenting it is not only about analysing the external factors but also about embodying the design process. This methodology adds a performative dimension, making my design process an act of self-exploration and advocacy. Direct lived experience will offer profound insights that traditional research methodologies might overlook. Instead of relying on detached observations, by using this research approach, I will capture the emotions and daily realities. My personal journey would serve as a lens to explore broader systemic barriers. My experience is not only a starting point but the core of my research; it will make practice-based methods authentic and impactful for my design project.

4.2. Visual Autoethnography

My curiosity lies in understanding the intersection of pregnancy and academia and how design interventions can make the challenges of pregnant students more evident in an educational environment. I aim to contribute to inclusive and participatory design in academia and the field of social design. Aligning with Metadesign principles, my research moves from predefined solutions to an open-ended and evolving process where design and research both emerge through the interplay of my experience and involvement with the institutional framework.

I documented my journey in real time using visual autoethnographic methods to explore and specify the challenges encountered by pregnant students. I adapted Ownby's (2011a) approach to visual autoethnography, which involved the primary data in narrative text and photographic images. This method requires visual and textual analysis for a broader understanding of the lived experience. Using this method and self-reflection, I examined the main concerns of the lack of supportive policies, institutional invisibility, and emotional and logistical obstacles to balance pregnancy, caregiving and educational responsibilities.

4.3. Non-Intrusive Approaches to Participatory Design

I invited participation in a non-intrusive manner by conducting a design intervention, such as installing an interactive board or a large poster on a wall in a public area at the university. The installation anonymously encourages both pregnant students and those who support pregnant and parenting students to contribute by placing stickers. They can also write reflections about the challenges they think pregnant students face in academic settings and take badges to promote visibility. This intervention serves as a discovery method and an invitation for engagement.

In my design process, I apply this non-intrusive method to investigate the visibility of parenting students on university premises. The absence of lactation rooms and child daycare on campus suggests that parenting students are structurally invisible. Applying Donna Haraway's (1988) perspective of situated knowledge, I recognise how the experiences of caregiving students are often excluded from institutional narratives. This invisibility highlights what Bergers (1972) describe as exclusionary ways of seeing, how the dominant points of view shape what should be visible and whose realities should be acknowledged.

According to Emden and Smith (2003, p.40), "Non-intrusive methods do not generally require the approval of a human research ethics committee because they don't involve active participation by people. As can be seen, though, people (or their products or possessions) are

part of the non-intrusive process and researchers are obliged to consider issues of confidentiality and privacy".

While the design project initially involves non-intrusive data collection, such as analysing institutional policies, it also introduces a participatory design intervention (Parenting Student Wall/ Board), which will be discussed in more detail below. This interactive board includes an element of voluntary participation. At the same time, no formal consent process is required. However, ethical considerations about privacy, confidentiality, and the principle of " no harm shall be done" would remain crucial. Students will participate anonymously; no personal data will be collected. Nevertheless, the project remains conscious of the potential risks and ensures that participation does not lead to unexpected harm or scrutiny.

"The way in which each sees the other confirms his own view of himself" – **John Berger, 1972**

4.4. Performative Design for Situated Visibility

In this design project, "Performative" refers to the acts generated through embodiment, public participation and situated experiences. Drawing upon Judith Butler's theory of Performativity (1990), where the act of doing turns into the form of knowing and how performative acts constitute identity and challenge dominant narratives. Carl DiSalvo (2009) describes performative design as a means to provoke the public, using design to stage questions, challenge systemic structures and create spaces for reflection. In my project, I used performative design to challenge institutional invisibility and make parenting students present through symbolic and material actions.

5. DESIGN PROCESS

Through my practice-based research, I demonstrated insights from self-reflection and translated my design interventions into tangible actions. Rather than creating fixed and structured solutions, I emphasised building conditions that foster engagement and visibility. This includes:

5.1. A Journey Map

A journey map installation that serves as a visual and evolving documentation of my pregnancy and parenting journey, updating every day through images and text in the form of performative writing, turning my personal experience and struggles into a public research artefact. My journey map is a testament to my "Then" pregnant students and "Now" parenting student challenges and day-to-day struggles. It does not just contain small reflections, but one can see the sleepless nights, stress before submission and moments of feeding and diaper change while managing mute and off-camera zoom calls. This long piece of paper looks like a very creative piece of art. However, it is a reality for many student moms juggling their dual roles, fulfilling their caregiving responsibilities while keeping up

with their ambitions and dreams. According to Richard Sennett, author of The Craftsman (2009), we get so involved in the process that we are no longer aware of ourselves; even the bodily self, we become the thing on which we spend time mastering. In this whole process of

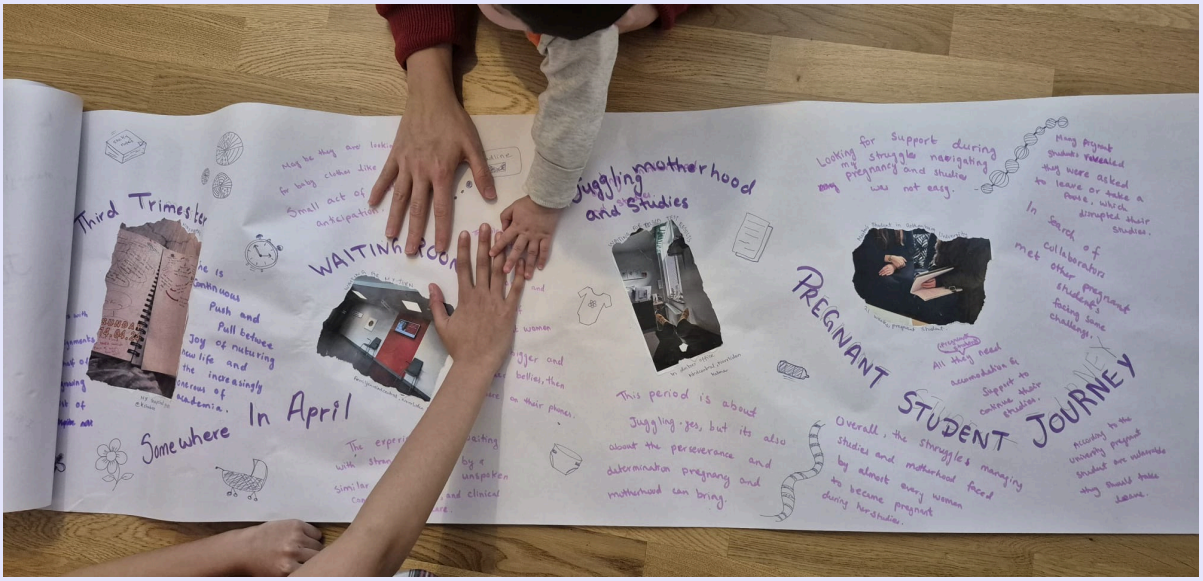


Figure 5. Journey Map (Visual Autoethnography), K.shabee (2025)

creating a personal reflective artefact, I am absorbed, and it feels like it is not just a paper with pictures and text doodles. In fact, that journey map is like I'm talking to myself, motivating and navigating on my own to pursue my dreams and ambitions, along with my responsibilities.

5.2. The Parenting Student Wall/Board

To encourage participation, I created a low-barrier engagement tool, such as an interactive board or a public wall at a university. This allowed students to express their support and challenges anonymously and highlight the collective nature of the issue. This intervention provided a lasting presence, ensuring recognition. It was a public statement that pregnant and parenting students exist and deserve recognition.



Figure 6, Figure 7.Process of making badges and parenting student board, K.Shabee (2025)

It served as a declaration of the needs and challenges of pregnant and parenting students, creating both physical and symbolic space for ongoing visibility and support. Through this, I aimed to spark conversation and a push for change.



Figure 8.Parenting student board, K.shabee (2025)

The initial challenge in creating this wall was securing an ideal space within the university. I envisioned the wall in a public area at Linnaeus University, Växjö campus. After three weeks of waiting for a response from the university administration, I decided to move forward and I explore alternative options. I considered focusing on doing something in the design department, believing it would start a discussion and generate momentum. So, I opted for a simple whiteboard displaying designed text and badges to encourage engagement with this small design intervention.

Figure 9. Laser cut badges, K.Shabee (2025)

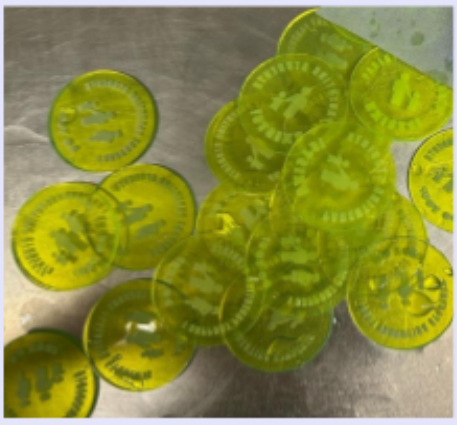
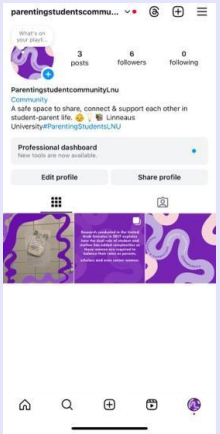


Figure 10. Parenting student community instagram account, K.Shabee (2025)



Fortunately, a spare whiteboard was available in the design department.To collect data in an unconventional manner, I designed three different types of badges for parenting and non-parenting students. Simple laser-cut typography on the board provides instructions for participation. As a part of the process of building a community of parenting students, I established a social media account. This allows me to raise awareness, share information and connect with new parenting students.

The process of making everything, from arranging a whiteboard to the whole laser-cutting process of badges and text for the board, proved time-consuming. Despite two weeks of struggle, I successfully displayed the board in the M-building at Linnaeus University Växjö campus. In contrast, the final product differs from what I envisioned. However, I was pleased to have a platform to collect students' reflections as part of the design process. The next challenge was engaging people. I found that the process of making and displaying the board was easy and straightforward, but the challenge was activating the board. Conventional posters and marketing were insufficient, so I opted for gorilla marketing tactics and something unusual to pique curiosity. I decided to attach physical probes on posters like baby diapers and place them on the university washroom wall and other places, especially in areas where I encountered difficulties. The university has a gender-neutral washroom but lacks a

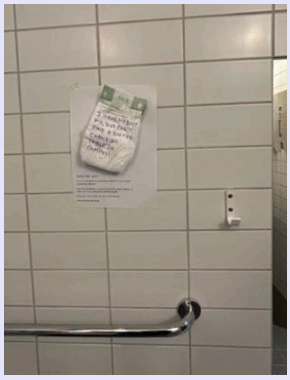






Figure 11. Poster in the washroom, K.Shabee (2025)
Figure 12.Poster on the microwave, Dining area M-building, K.Shabee (2025)
Figure 13. A poster outside of Vilarum Design Department, K.Shabee (2025)

diaper-changing table. Every department has more than five microwaves in the dining area, but none for children's food. There are resting spaces (Vilarum) for students, and not many students are aware of it, so why not have a lactation room as well? This disparity underscored the absence of structural support for parenting students, creating an unwelcoming environment for students with children. The lack of basic childcare facilities prevents students from bringing their young children to campus. It also emphasises that the university operates under the assumption that students are unencumbered, making parenting students invisible and their needs are overlooked.

5.3. Reflections: “Support”, “Struggle” and “Solidarity”

After one week of displaying the board on campus, I gathered interesting reflections from students. Parenting, pregnant and non-parenting students' responses focused on support, struggle and solidarity. The students expressed support and encouragement and praised the bravery of balancing parenthood and studies while advocating for inclusivity in academic settings. The reflections suggested a call for collective action, forming alliances and advocating for improved infrastructure to support parenting students at Linnaeus University.

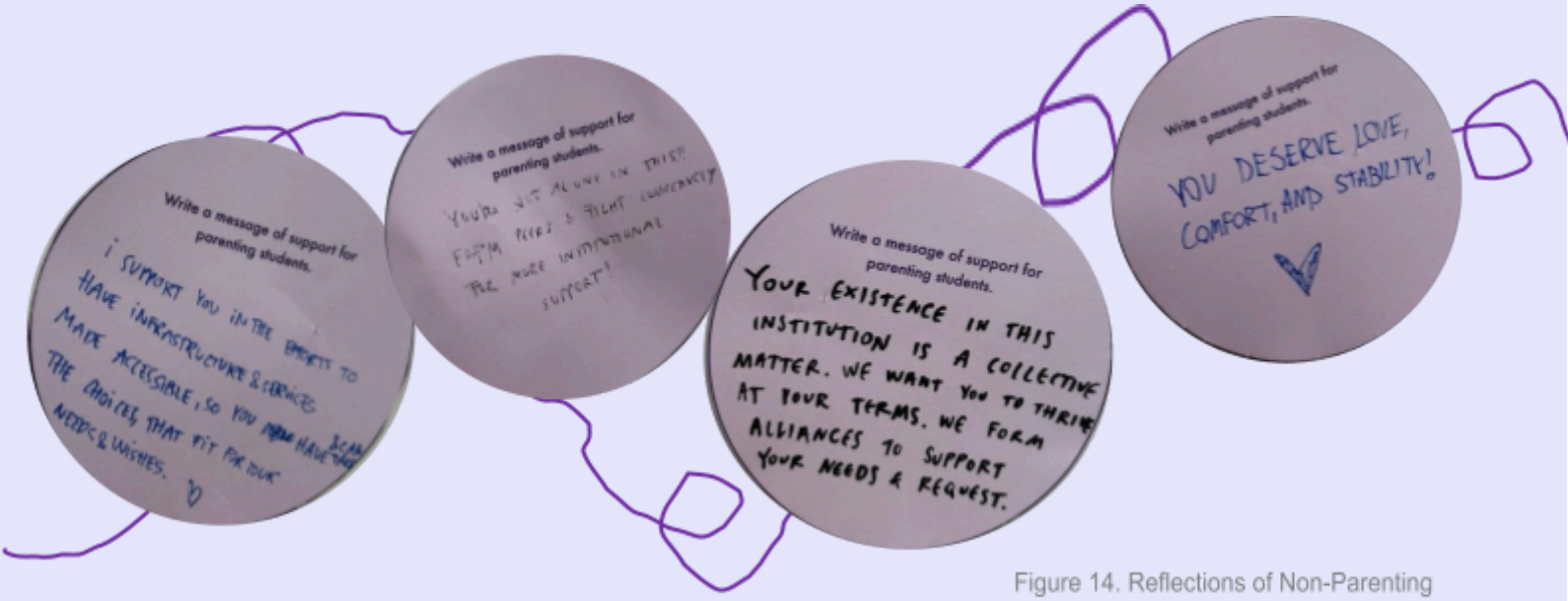


Figure 14. Reflections of Non-Parenting Students K.Shabee (2025)

Nevertheless, the responses from parenting students reveal strong contrasts, highlighting the challenges of balancing responsibilities and demonstrating the overwhelming personal struggles that occur with combining parenthood and studies. One optimistic reflection, however, from a parenting student indicates perseverance and the importance of setting a

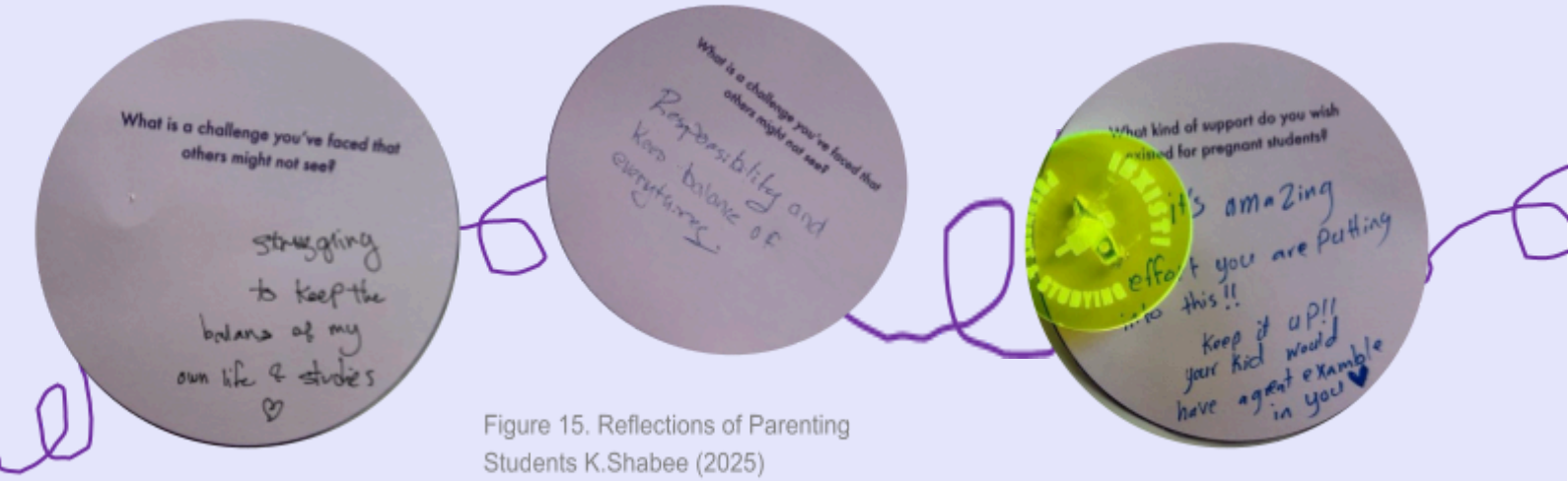


Figure 15. Reflections of Parenting Students K.Shabee (2025)

strong example for their child. This distinction between external encouragement and internal struggles uncovers the gap between perceived and lived experiences. Eventually, the

reflections suggest the need for institutional support that is not just symbolic but provides tangible solutions for parenting students on campus.

5.4. Pregnancy to Parenting: An Empathy Jacket Experience

Inspired by my embodied experience of being pregnant and parenting while studying, exploring embodied design methods and feminist care theory, I created the empathy jacket. The idea of this empathy jacket is that we do not just think through our minds but also through our bodies.



Figure 16. Process of empathy jacket prototype, K Shabee (2025)



Figure 17. Empathy jacket prototype, K Shabee (2025)

I wanted others, such as non-parenting students, to experience and feel what it means to carry both care and ambition, not just through discussions, but through their bodies. Without any fancy materials and proper calculations, I intended to make this jacket. I bought clothes from a secondhand shop and hand-stitched the pouch on the back of the jacket that would be worn on the front. I filled it with a bag of lentils available at home to make it look almost like the third trimester of pregnancy, and 3.2 kg heavy as a pregnant belly. I put text on the front of the jacket that reflects the concept of parenting while studying. This DIY process of making a jacket resonates with the concept of "Jugaad", the Urdu word meaning a clever hack. As Navi Radjou and Jaideep Prabhu write in Jugaad Innovation (2012), "Jugaad is doing more with less, it's about turning adversity into opportunity".

Tough pregnancy empathy suits exist. However, this jacket is my own form of design intervention with what I have, which encourages performative wearing and experiencing the transformation from pregnancy to parenting in an academic environment. I invited non-parenting students to experience the two phases of the jacket with some instructions. The

first phase(pregnancy) participant was asked to wear a pregnant belly on the front for 5- 10 minutes and to perform small tasks such as picking up objects from the floor. In the second phase (parenting), they had to wear a pregnant belly on the back while carrying a baby doll and a baby diaper bag and perform small tasks that they do when they are in university. During this process, I documented the performance with the consent of the participants.



Figure 18. MFA2- Design+Change Students, testing the prototype, K Shabee (2025)

Ultimately, they were asked to reflect on their experience wearing this empathy jacket and what they felt physically and emotionally during both phases. I got fascinating reflections that made me so glad that my small jugaad was so effective, which really made people feel the complexity of being pregnant and parenting during studies.



Figure 19. Reflections of non-parenting students, MFA2 Design + Change, Linnaeus University, Växjo. K Shabee (2025)

Additionally, I created a poetic video showing shifting the weight from front pregnancy to back parenting. I wrote a poem, "Visible Care," and voiced over it in the video, demonstrating how the form of care changes, but it never goes away.

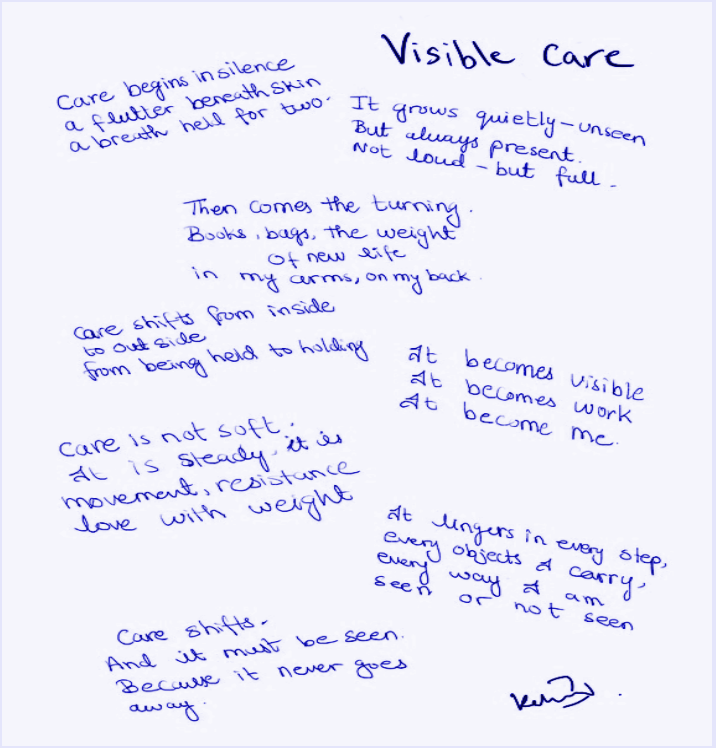


Figure 20. Visible care poem, K. Shabee (2025)

5.5. Speculative Tool: Support Policy Guide Brochure

Initially, I considered creating a demo policy book or a manifesto, but I want to create something that can be applied on a broader scale. This led to the idea of creating a brochure for new, upcoming pregnant and parenting students. In that brochure, I outlined the university's ostensible support system, such as the resources and facilities for students with



Figure 21. Mock up of Speculative tool: Policy guide brochure for new Students, K. Shabee (2025)

caregiving responsibilities, which in reality are often inadequate or entirely absent. I presented the fictional yet desirable offerings in the brochure, which would act as a speculative tool to critique current universities' practices.

I proposed this to the Linnaeus University administration, raising the question of why such resources are not already available, and suggested that this kind of brochure be included in every student's welcome package. Unlike a manifesto, which usually demands immediate change, this brochure is a subtle speculation offering a potential framework for support rather than a declaration. This small yet meaningful gesture signals that parenting students are seen, supported and valued from day one. It also challenges the university to consider why parenting students are excluded from mainstream support material and visibility. It serves as a critical reflection on the university's policies.

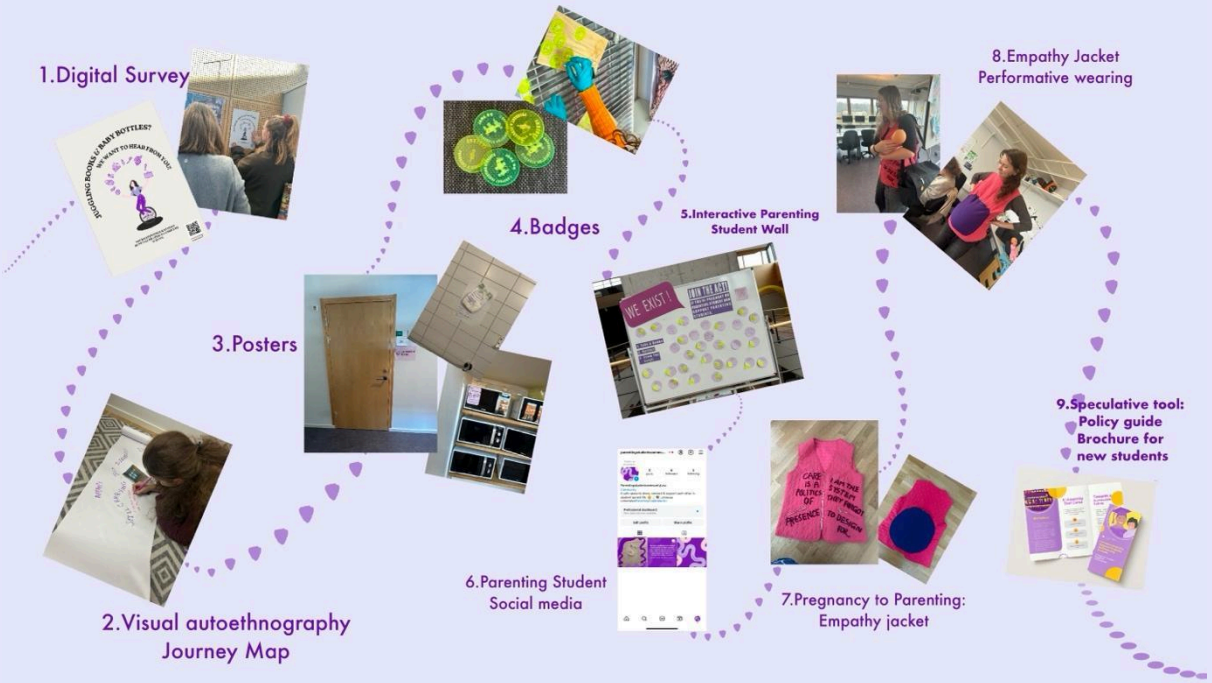


Figure 22. Design process and interventions journey, K. Shabee (2025)

Though uncertain how the university would respond to this proposal, the management reacted positively. They appreciated the initiative and forwarded it to the relevant department for further consideration.

In my process, I explored design through creative and experimental methods by questioning and engaging with institutional and academic systems. I investigated various designs and research works to understand how my approach is similar or different. My design process aligns with Metadesign because instead of creating a defined solution, I allowed my ideas and possibilities to emerge naturally. My project research and process evolved and adapted as I gained new insights and interactions.

6. TO IMPLEMENT AND EXHIBIT

For implementation, the project does not follow the traditional linear model; the design actions themselves act as interventions that challenge norms and make the invisible visible. The design interventions were open-ended and self-organising, aligning with Metadesign

principles where outcomes emerge rather than being strictly predetermined. Rather than implementing a final solution, I disrupted the dominant narratives, invited participation and initiated dialogue to contribute to long-term systemic change. The journey map is an artefact, demonstrating a personal yet critical reflection on pregnancy in academia. The interactive board collects responses over time and serves as a participatory document of student voices. The policy guide brochure will be used as an advocacy tool and presented to the university administration and students to push for institutional recognition and support.

While these symbolic and participatory artefacts are integral to the design process, the pregnancy and parenting empathy jacket, alongside the Visible Care video, form a core of the final public display. It is anticipated that this initiative will resonate beyond the university's walls. These elements demonstrate the personal narratives and lived experience of being a student-parent. The display seeks to spark conversation among people by inviting individuals to engage with the empathy jacket philosophically and creatively. It draws attention to the complicated ways students navigate their studies, along with their caregiving responsibilities.

The empathy jacket, therefore, transcends its role as a mere exhibit, acting as an instigator of a dialogue for broader change, hoping that this initiative will resonate with people and encourage other institutions to consider norms that have perhaps rarely been questioned. Individuals, particularly students, adapted the existing conditions without considering alternatives that mask the larger systemic issue, such as the perceived incompatibility of pregnancy and parenting with academic pursuits.

7. CRITICAL REFLECTION

In this process, I realised that it is important to address more profound questions such as: What contribution can I make? What do I leave behind for others? How can we make something long-term and ensure social sustainability and support for pregnant students? Raising awareness is very important, but will it lead to real changes in university policies? Does showing the problem help to solve it, or do I need to do more?

Initially, I aimed to seek diverse perspectives from co-creation and direct engagement. However, due to a lack of participation, I realised that the silence and invisibility surrounding this issue are the key research findings for this project. This unveils how pregnant students are excluded from academic discourse.

7.1.Embracing Uncertainty

Embracing uncertainty and utilising design as inquiry, I adapted my research rather than abandoning it; my project reinforces the importance of speculative and performative research methodology. As Tracey and Hutchinson (2016) argue, " Uncertainty in the design space is a subject ripe for deeper exploration, as is the role of individual designers' attitudes toward uncertainty". Instead of imposing a predefined framework, I created opportunities for engagement through my interventions. I think the difficult part of this project is balancing my personal experience with objective analysis. Often, the research aims to be neutral, but I feel that sharing my own experience strengthens it and aligns with feminist research methods that value personal stories as meaningful knowledge. The Metadesign principles inform my approach by positioning it as a flexible and evolving process rather than a defined set of solutions. I can't control how many students participate. Still, the presence of an interactive

board/wall and a journey map confirms that the issue occupies space in a way that traditional research methods might not achieve.

Even though I faced challenges initially, this helped me to understand the problem deeply and reassess the process. I believe my installation, interactive board and manifesto serve as an artefact that future pregnant and parenting students can build upon and ensure that visibility and discussions of challenges faced by pregnant students extend beyond the duration of this design project. The project demonstrates how lived experience can serve as both research and activism, opening pathways for exploration and systemic change.

7.2. Evaluating The Impact

It is not possible to measure the success of my design intervention solely by how many parenting students participated in and engaged with the parenting wall or took a badge. However, visibility is a crucial initiative in stimulating recognition; It does not necessarily lead to academic policy change. To evaluate the impact of the project, I documented the participation through direct observations, feedback and informal interviews with the broader university community, not only focusing on parenting students. The main indicators for the favourable outcome of the interactive intervention were: Do the parenting students feel a strong sense of connection? Do teachers and administrators notice the issue? Do discussions emerge about institutional support? It was important to make this intervention sustainable beyond its initial phase, which requires continuous engagement from both parenting students and other students in the university. To make sure that the Parenting wall/ board would remain an active platform rather than a static artefact, it depends on and evolves through students' initiatives and faculty involvement.

Additionally, there were some limitations that must be acknowledged, such as whether the visibility initiates a discussion for concrete change. How does this intervention inspire lasting change? I hoped this intervention would serve as a catalyst for dialogue on inclusivity within the educational environment, rather than being just a standalone effort. I wanted to position my project as an open-ended, participatory initiative that encourages a culture of ongoing discussion and action, which also has the potential to grow beyond its initial scope.

> “An oppressed group's experiences may put its members in a position to see things differently, but their lack of control over the ideological apparatuses of society makes expressing a self-defined standpoint more difficult.”
> **– Patricia Hill Collins**

7.3. Navigating Subjectivity as a Researcher and a Participant

To navigate my position in the project as both a participant and a researcher shapes this design project. My lived experience as a former pregnant student provides insider knowledge and also emphasises the aspect of subjectivity. To understand this, I draw on feminist research methodologies such as Haraway’s (1988) situated knowledge, which discusses that all

knowledge is partial and indicated by lived experience. Instead of detachment, I adapted the autoethnographical methods, realising that a personal narrative is also an authentic form of knowledge production. With autoethnography, researchers use their own stories to get involved with people, culture, and other aspects of social research. During the process, we confront "the tension between insider and outsider perspectives, between social practice and social research"(Adams, Holman Jones, and Ellis, 2015).

According to Patricia Hill Collin's concept of the "outsider within" (1990), the individuals belonging to a marginalised group have access to places of privilege or power, and their experiences allow them to see and understand the system from inside and outside standpoints. I also embody this outsider within perspective. As a student, I personally experienced the struggles of managing studies and motherhood, which provides insider knowledge that other non-parenting students or faculty may not have. As a researcher, I critically evaluate these struggles, designing interventions to address institutional norms and to increase visibility for parenting students. My dual role enables me to see both perspectives; I comprehend the challenges faced by pregnant and parenting students while also examining how the university framework perpetuates invisibility and exclusion. This notion makes my research strong; it validates my lived experience as an analytical tool rather than a bias. This aligns with feminist and participatory research that values knowledge produced from personal lived realities rather than detached observation.

7.4. Need for Empathy Beyond Awareness

During the process, I discovered that the absence of institutional support is not only an issue; there is also a crucial social issue, especially among young students who seem to idealise unencumbered student life. While the unconventional posters were designed to grab the attention of students, they also sparked discussions about "Why do we support pregnant and parenting students?". "Everyone should get an abortion". This made me wonder why this kind of view exists. Perhaps that is because they never experienced those hardships and perceived the project as insignificant. This revelation informed my next step. That led me to create a sensorial experience that not only raises awareness but allows everyone to experience and reflect in parallel. That might foster empathy and care among non-parenting students because real cultural change and the push for institutional policies need the engagement of the entire student body, not just a few parenting students.

7.5. Visible Care

As Dooren (2014) highlights, care is not just an idea; it has physical and emotional weight. Caring involves thinking and feelings; it is a moral responsibility. Care is a moral responsibility; it is not optional. True care involves both thinking and feeling; it's not soft or instinctive but complex. This design project highlights the overlooked reality of parenting students who navigate the demanding intersection of care and ambition. It also seeks to foster awareness and evoke emotional understanding among non-parenting students. For instance, the caregiving roles of parenting students, specifically during pregnancy and after as a parent, represent a constant and invisible burden within educational settings. Ultimately, this project advocates for an inclusive and empathic educational environment that genuinely supports the dual roles of student-parents and recognises care as central to academic life.

CONCLUSION

This project began by addressing the institutional invisibility of student-parents, who are often overlooked in the design of academic life. Inspired by personal experience, it evolved into a broader critical design inquiry by using tools such as visual autoethnography, participatory design activities and performative artefacts to challenge normative assumptions and provoke discussion. Instead of offering predefined solutions, this design project embraced uncertainty and focused on creating conditions for visibility and conversations. Embedded in feminist and Metadesign principles, it classified the lived experience as valid knowledge and placed care as both an ethical stance and a structural demand.

Through materiality, symbolically and socially, this project makes care visible and contributes to a broader dialogue about inclusion in higher education and institutions. The outcomes, from the pregnancy-to-parenting empathy jacket to the speculative support guide brochure for new student-parents, are not endpoints but starting points. These artefacts are tools for awareness, advocacy and potential change. This project invites educational institutions to leap ahead, not to take over and decide for them, but to support and create conditions for student-parents in ways that recognise their full realities.

As a designer, this project shifted my perspective on how I see myself as a designer. Throughout this journey, I realised that I am not just creating things, but designing care infrastructures. My future practice would be amplifying marginalised voices through design, making people's invisible lives visible and designing systems that support rather than exclude.

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APPENDICES

The following appendices include extended notes and documentation of the project's Interventions and activities.

Appendix A: Digital Surveys

Contains the questionnaire to gather initial data about pregnant and parenting students at Linnaeus University Växjö, Sweden, includes anonymous responses and interest in participation.

Appendix B: Journey Map

A visual autoethnographic documentation of the day-to-day experience of pregnancy and studies. This document is used to reflect on institutional gaps and psychological state.

Appendix C: Posters (Guerrilla marketing)

Documentation of posters placed in various spaces of the university campus to attract attention and spark dialogue to increase visibility for pregnant and parenting students.

Appendix D: Parenting Student Board/ Wall and Badges

Notes and pictures from interactive board intervention, including badges, responses, and reflections on visibility.

Appendix E: Pregnancy to parenting: Empathy jacket Experience

Images and reflections of the wearable empathy jacket- a performative and symbolic tool to convey the embodied challenges of parenting students.

Appendix F: Speculative Tool: Support Policy Guide Brochure

Design outcome intended to provoke institutional change: a speculative policy guide and awareness brochure to propose student-parent-friendly futures.